rather than its ICBMs to wage nuclear war. The British V-bombers would be several hours ahead of the bulk of SAC's aircraft, flying from the US. Bomber Command would therefore be in the vanguard of the attack, tasked with taking out Soviet air defence and control, and opening penetration routes for SAC. With growing concern over the ability of the V-bombers to penetrate Soviet air space, Bomber Command's targets evolved over time. By August 1962 British-assigned targets comprised sixteen cities, fourteen airfields, twenty-eight IRBM bases, and ten air defence systems. This target set may have converged with the national plan. The Thors, it should be noted, were never assigned to this, as operational independence was a prerequisite for inclusion in the national plan.

The UK national plan reflected the British way in nuclear war (i.e., targeting cities). Although it was inconceivable to many that Britain would ever fight a nuclear war against the Soviet Union alone, the need for 'an independent deterrent' was a source of debate and political controversy during the Cold War.

Precise details of Soviet targeting have not appeared, though Soviet nuclear weapons were aimed at the United States and Western Europe. Daniel Ellsberg suggests that Soviet attacks on Western Europe might have caused another one hundred million fatalities.[28] In July 1961 the National Security Council was informed that a Soviet surprise attack on the United States in 1963 would kill between forty-eight and seventy-one million people with immediate effect, rising to between sixty-seven and seventy-six million within a month.[29] When the Joint Chiefs briefed the President on the SIOP in July 1961, they made clear there was no guarantee that a US first strike would prevent some retaliation against the United States.[30] Daniel Ellsberg records that he was told that the Joint Chiefs believed a pre-emptive attack on the Soviet Union might result in fewer than ten million fatalities in the US.[31]

Such calculations, nevertheless, assumed a US (or US-led) first strike did not decapitate the Soviet government and its system of nuclear command and control. The Soviets developed a highly centralised system of command and control which was intended to ensure that only the leadership of the Communist Party should decide on nuclear war. Decapitation poses risk to